I WHAT ARE YOU LAUGHING AT?

The Roman writer Seneca once commented: "All things are cause either for laughter or weeping." The 18th-century French dramatist Pierre-Augustin Beaumarchais echoed Seneca's words by stating: "I hasten to laugh at everything, for fear of being obliged to weep." Both Seneca and Beaumarchais understood that laughing and crying are closely related emotional responses to some kind of outside stimulus. They knew that in life, as in drama, comedy and tragedy are never far apart. Both laughing and crying serve to release tension. Laughter, like weeping, is a reflex action rooted in the central nervous system and its related hormones. It is expressed in the contraction of certain facial muscles and in altered breathing patterns. The stimulus that brings forth laughter is called humour. To define laughter and humour in this way, however, is to leave unanswered two questions: firstly, why do people laugh; and secondly, just what is funny, or humorous? The questions are difficult to answer because emotions and the reasons for them are not easily analyzed.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

COLUMN A **COLUMN B**

a) crying . . . . .

b) repeat what someone else has meant; repeat or imitate the words, sentiments, etc. of a person . . . . .

c) act quickly . . . . .

d) (be) made to feel it is necessary to do something . . . . .

e) relating to feelings . . . . .

f) reaction to something . . . . .

g) something which causes someone or something to react in a certain way . . . . .

h) perform a function . . . . .

i) (be) caused by; originate from *(phrase)* . . . . .

j) the act of becoming smaller or shorter . . . . .

k) relating to the face . . . . .

l) changed . . . . .

m) produce; cause to happen *(phrase)* . . . . .

n) examine closely and in detail in order to understand . . . . .

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. Seneca and Beaumarchais would have agreed that . . . . . .

A) there is nothing in life that cannot be seen as funny in some way
B) it is necessary to cry if something isn't at all humorous
C) the best way to deal with unpleasant events is to laugh at them
D) everything in life could be seen as either humorous or tragic
E) you should be careful about whether a particular situation requires you to laugh or to cry

2. Laughing and crying are similar in that . . . . . .

A) each action provides the body with stimulation
B) they both leave people somewhat relaxed
C) they are both the result of excessive hormones
D) many people cannot distinguish the difference between them
E) they are produced by the same stimuli

3. It is difficult to define humour and identify the causes of laughter because . . . . . .

A) people find it difficult to look at comedy seriously
B) most people are much more concerned with tragedy
C) people get nervous when being studied and so cannot laugh
D) the physical responses to humour are already known
E) there is no easy way to study emotions scientifically

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. Most things get smaller in cold weather, so engineers must consider the effects of this ……when designing buildings and bridges.
2. I don't actually enjoy buying Christmas presents for my family, but as it is a longstanding tradition, I'm……to do it if I don't want to hurt their feelings.
3. Isaac has few ideas of his own and simply tends to……whatever his older brother says.
4. If you're planning to go anywhere during the upcoming holiday, I recommend that you ……to book your tickets now. If you wait, all the planes may be full up.
5. Delia went to Budapest on holiday and when she returned, her appearance was so ……that I hardly recognized her. It seems that she went there for cosmetic surgery.